Where You Are: The Financial Step, What Comes Before It and What Comes After

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

When Mom's care is being paid for every month and everyone has a rule about her money, it can feel as if the whole question belongs to this week, and to you. There is a general order to it, and the money questions are one step of nine.

This page shows the whole road, where the financial step sits on it, what comes before and after, and who does which part.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1 **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
You finish with: Immediate Care Needs Assessment

2 **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
You finish with: Financial Snapshot & Care Cost Analysis

3 **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4 **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
You finish with: Medicaid Action Plan

5 **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
You finish with: Legal Issues & Attorney Review Brief

6 **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
You finish with: Financial Strategy & Implementation Plan

You are here. This step is about the money questions that come up while Mom's care is being paid for. Your family's part is to get the monthly picture, the money decisions on the table and your questions onto paper. The step is finished when any financial strategy agreed upon with the appropriate professionals has been carried out with them, and the family's updated financial position is documented for the Medicaid application.

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7 **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
You finish with: Medicaid Application File

8 **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
You finish with: Asset Protection Report

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System
You finish with: Medicaid Maintenance Plan

What comes before it

Two steps in this phase sit ahead of this one. The Plan step ends in a written plan. The Legal step ends in an attorney's review. The financial step follows them because money decisions are meant to fit the plan and the legal advice the family has been given.

Legal advice and legal documents belong to an elder law attorney. The federal Administration for Community Living lists preparing power of attorney documents and exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid among the things elder law attorneys do. [2]

If your family arrived at this step first because the bill is already coming every month, the conversation can start from what you have, with the gaps marked as questions.

What this step produces

The Financial Strategy & Implementation Plan. It sets out the financial issues, the strategies to evaluate, the approved actions, their sequencing, the documentation requirements and the updated financial position. Your family brings the first part: the issues, and the paper behind them. The evaluating, approving and ordering are done with your Medicaid planner and the licensed professionals named below.

The plan is not a decision about eligibility. The Administration for Community Living explains that the states operate Medicaid day to day, including taking applications and making determinations of eligibility. [1]

What comes after it

Apply is next: the application is prepared, submitted and managed. After it come Protect and Maintain. The roadmap shows the steps in a general order. Which of them your family needs, and when, is part of Mom's own plan.

The records from this step go with you. The Administration for Community Living says a person applying has to provide documentation to verify the financial requirements, and that anyone applying on another person's behalf should have access to their financial records. [1]

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: writing down what care costs, the money decisions made or being considered and your questions, and keeping the statements, receipts and contracts.
- Mom: her own wishes about her money, as far as she can share them.
- Your Medicaid planner: reviews how Medicaid rules may apply to a proposed financial action before it is taken, coordinates with the other professionals, and helps the family put approved actions in order, document what was done and bring the financial picture up to date before the application.
- An elder law attorney: anything that needs legal review.
- A licensed insurance professional or a licensed financial professional: any insurance or financial product.
- An applications specialist and the state Medicaid agency: the application is prepared with a specialist, and the state makes the decision. That is step seven.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't put your family's own financial actions in order or say what any of them means for Medicaid, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. Families move through the steps at different speeds, and rules vary by state.

Ready for the next step?

You know where the financial step sits on the road and who does which part of it. The planning interview is a way to walk into it prepared: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner, or to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The statements about who takes applications and decides eligibility, what an applicant documents and what elder law attorneys do come from the Administration for Community Living.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?

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